CHAPTER 87 Pressure Groups

Meaning and Techniques

The term 'pressure group' was originated in the USA. A pressure group is a group of people who are organised actively for promoting and defending their common interests. It is so called as it attempts to bring a change in the public policy by exerting pressure on the government. It acts as a liaison between the government and its members.

The pressure groups are also called *interest groups* or vested groups. They are different from the political parties in that they neither contest elections nor try to capture political power. They are concerned with specific programmes and issues and their activities are confined to the protection and promotion of the interests of their members by influencing the government.

The pressure groups influence the policy-making and policy-implementation in the government through legal and legitimate methods like lobbying, correspondence, publicity, propagandising, petitioning, public debating, maintaining contacts with their legislators and so forth. However, some times they resort to illegitimate and illegal methods like strikes, violent activities and corruption which damages public interest and administrative integrity.

According to Odegard, pressure groups resort to three different techniques in securing their purposes. First, they can try to place in public office persons who are favourably disposed towards the interests they seek to promote. This technique may be labelled *electioneering*. Second, they can try to persuade public officers, whether they are initially favourably disposed toward them or not, to adopt and enforce the policies that they think will prove most beneficial to their interests. This technique may be labelled *lobbying.* Third, they can try to influence public opinion and thereby gain an indirect influence over the government, since the government in a democracy is substantially affected by public opinion. This technique may be labelled *propagandising*[1].

PRESSURE GROUPS IN INDIA

A large number of pressure groups exist in India. But, they are not developed to the same extent as in the US or the western countries like Britain, France, Germany and so on. The pressure groups in India can be broadly classified into the following categories:

1. Business Groups

The business groups include a large number of industrial and commercial bodies. They are the most sophisticated, the most powerful and the largest of all pressure groups in India. They include:

1. Federation of Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry (FICCI).
2. Associated Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India (ASSOCHAM).
3. Federation of All India Foodgrain Dealers Association (FAIFDA).
4. All-India Manufacturers Organisation (AIMO).

2. Trade Unions